

PRIMEBOOKS CURRICULUM SERIES

PrimeBooks Humanities Year 7

Year 7 · Lower Secondary

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| Y7: Exploring Our World – History & Geography

Year 7 Course Book · Lower Secondary · Prime School

PrimeBooks Humanities Year 7

Introduction

Welcome to Year 7 History and Geography

| Why this book matters

You are about to start a big adventure.

This book is not only about old dates and coloured maps. It is about **people** and **places** — and how they shape each other every day of history.

The course title is:

Y7: Exploring Our World – History & Geography

In Year 7 you study **History** and **Geography** together. We call this subject story **Humanities**. The year is organised by **school terms**, but the big ideas of the book are organised in two **Parts**:

- **Part 1** — Ancient and Pre-Columbian civilisations and landscapes
- **Part 2** — Europe, the UK and Portugal

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| What geography really is

Geography is not only “knowing where each country is on a map”.

Geography is the **stage** on which history happens.

Mountains, rivers, deserts, coasts, climate and cities **limit or help** what people can do. They create possibilities and obstacles.

| What history really is

History is not only a list of dates and names.

History is the story of how people:

- **adapted** to the places where they lived
- **changed** those places (cities, farms, roads, canals, walls...)
- and were **changed themselves** (new tools, new beliefs, new ways of living together)

| Two big ideas for the whole year

1. Nature shapes what is possible

A desert makes farming hard. A great river can feed cities. High mountains can separate peoples. Open seas can open trade.

2. People reshape nature

Humans dig canals, build terraces, raise walls, invent tools and draw borders. Beliefs and power change the land too.

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| The continuous cycle

Geography is not a frozen background. History is not a pile of loose events.

They form a cycle:

Place → limits and inspires people → people act and change the place → the new place creates new chances and new problems → and so on.

Whenever you study a past event, ask:

***Where** did this happen, and **how** did the place influence people — and how did people influence the place?*

| Three forces (simple Year 7 model)

Force	Simple meaning
Physical geography	What the land and water make possible
Economy	How people produce, trade and use resources
Socio-political context	Who has power, how society is organised, which ideas and conflicts matter

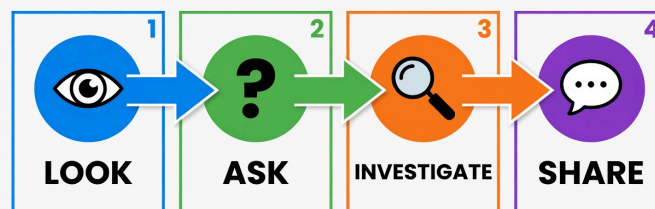
| Your enquiry process

Every chapter uses the same friendly process:

look → ask → investigate → share

Prime School Enquiry Process

look then ask then investigate then share



Prime School Enquiry Process — LOOK · ASK · INVESTIGATE · SHARE

| Imagine you are...

Imagine you open this book on the first morning of Year 7. On your desk sits a map of the world and a blank notebook. Your teacher smiles and says, “We will not only learn *what* people did. We will learn *where* they stood — and why that place mattered.”

You write one sentence in your notebook:

I will always ask where, and how the place helped or limited people.

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| Summary · Welcome

<!-- box:key-fact -->

Key points

1. This book is **Exploring Our World – History & Geography**.
2. **Geography** is the stage; **History** is the story of people on that stage.
3. Nature shapes what is possible; people reshape nature.
4. Always use the cycle: place → people act → place changes.
5. Every chapter follows **look** → **ask** → **investigate** → **share**.

<!-- /box:key-fact -->

| Check your understanding · Welcome

1. In your own words, what is **geography** in this book?
 2. In your own words, what is **history** in this book?
 3. Why is a river a good example of nature shaping what is possible?
 4. What three forces work together in our simple Year 7 model?
 5. Harder: Explain the continuous cycle using one place you already know (your town, a beach, a mountain, or a city you have visited).
-

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How to Use This Book

Why this section matters

A good book is like a journey. If you know how the path works, you will not get lost — and you will enjoy the view.

Step by step · How the book is designed

1. Start with the big picture

Maps and timelines show **where** and **when**.

2. Zoom into case studies

You will meet the Inca, China, Egypt, landscapes, maps, the UK and Portugal in careful detail.

3. Return to the big picture

At the end of units you look back with stronger understanding.

4. Keep a Thinking Journal

In a notebook or folder you should:

- sketch or paste small maps
- draw simple timelines
- stick in source images your teacher allows
- write questions that pop into your head

Your journal becomes a **visible record** of your thinking — not only correct answers, but better questions.

Two Parts, two colours (idea)

Part	Theme	Colour idea
Part 1	Ancient worlds and landscapes	Warm earth / mountain tones
Part 2	Maps, Europe, UK, Portugal	Ocean / European blue-green

Teaching still follows **terms** in school. The Parts help you see the **theme**.

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| Features you will meet in chapters

Feature	What it is for
Big Question	The main puzzle of the chapter
Key vocabulary	Important words in bold the first time
Story Time	Guides help you enter the topic
In Depth	Careful teaching of the ideas
Your Turn / Enquiry	Practice after teaching
Images	Photos and diagrams to help you *see*

| Labels

- **[GEOGRAPHY]** — places, maps, environments, how people live with them
- **[HISTORY]** — people, power, evidence and change over time

Read **[GEOGRAPHY]** chapters with maps first.

Read **[HISTORY]** chapters with timelines and sources first — then always ask about place.

| Imagine you are...

Imagine your Thinking Journal is a treasure chest. Every time you draw a map or write a question, you drop a coin of understanding inside. By June, the chest is heavy — not with gold, but with *ways of thinking*.

| Summary · How to Use This Book

<!-- box:key-fact -->

Key points

1. The book is a journey: big picture → detail → big picture again.
2. Keep a **Thinking Journal**.
3. Part 1 = ancient worlds and landscapes; Part 2 = Europe, UK, Portugal.
4. Use **[GEOGRAPHY]** and **[HISTORY]** labels carefully.
5. Read teaching first; answer questions second.

<!-- /box:key-fact -->

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Check your understanding · How to Use This Book

1. What four things can you put in a Thinking Journal?
 2. What is the difference between Part 1 and Part 2?
 3. What should you do first in a chapter — the quiz or the teaching?
 4. Harder: Why might a question in your journal be as useful as a correct answer?
-

Timelines, Maps and Big Ideas

| Why this section matters

Historians and geographers ask different first questions — and both questions matter.

- **Timelines** answer: *When?*
- **Maps** answer: *Where?*
- **Big Ideas** answer: *Why does this matter?*

If you only know *when*, you float in empty space.

If you only know *where*, you miss change over time.

If you never ask *why*, facts stay cold.

| Timelines · step by step

A **timeline** puts events in order from earlier to later.

You will build timelines for:

- the **Inca**
- **Ancient China**
- **Ancient Egypt**
- **Portugal** in the Middle Ages

Tips:

1. Mark a start and an end.
2. Place events carefully — not everything is the same “size” of importance.
3. Leave space for “we do not know exactly”. Historians are honest about uncertainty.

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| Maps · step by step

A **map** is a scaled drawing of part of Earth's surface.

Maps show location, distance, direction, height and sometimes change over time.

Important map ideas you will practise:

Idea	Meaning
Scale	How map distance matches real distance
Key (legend)	What symbols and colours mean
Direction	Which way is north
Grid / coordinates	How to find a place precisely

Remember: every map is made for a **purpose**. It shows some things and hides others.

| Big Ideas · step by step

Every chapter has one or two powerful **Big Questions**, for example:

- How can a river create a civilisation?
- How does geography help an empire grow — and later help it fall?

Read the Big Question at the **start**.

Answer it with **evidence** at the **end**.

| Visual rule for this book

Never study new content “in the air”. Keep a small **timeline strip** or a **locator map** nearby so you do not feel lost in time or space.

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Imagine you are...

Imagine you are a detective. Someone hands you a broken pot, a dusty letter and a blank map. Without a timeline, you do not know if the pot is 500 or 5,000 years old. Without a map, you do not know if the letter came from a mountain valley or a river city. With both, the past starts talking.

Summary · Timelines, Maps and Big Ideas

<!-- box:key-fact -->

Key points

1. Timelines answer **When?**
2. Maps answer **Where?**
3. Big Ideas answer **Why does this matter?**
4. Every map has a purpose and can hide information.
5. Always keep time and place in view together.

<!-- /box:key-fact -->

Check your understanding · Timelines, Maps and Big Ideas

1. What question does a timeline answer?
 2. What question does a map answer?
 3. Name two map skills you will practise this year.
 4. Why might two maps of the same place look different?
 5. Harder: Invent a Big Question for a place you know well (school, town or holiday place).
-

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| Skills Toolkit: Enquiry, Sources, Maps and Evidence

| Why this section matters

This is one of the most important parts of the whole book.

You will use these skills in **every** chapter — Inca mountains, Chinese rivers, the Nile, African landscapes, European maps and Portuguese castles.

If you learn the toolkit well, later chapters feel easier. If you rush past it, later chapters feel foggy.

| Four tools

Tool	Simple meaning
Enquiry	A four-step thinking process that turns curiosity into knowledge
Sources	Raw materials: objects, buildings, texts, pictures, landscapes, oral stories
Maps	Special sources that show location, distance, direction, height and sometimes change
Evidence	What we can fairly claim after carefully examining sources

| Enquiry · look → ask → investigate → share

1. Look

Observe a map, image, object or short text carefully. Notice details.

2. Ask

Write a focused question. Good questions are not huge foggy clouds. They are sharp.

3. Investigate

Use sources, maps and clear thinking. Cross-check when you can.

4. Share

Explain with evidence. Say what you know — and what you still do not know.

| Sources · step by step

When you meet a source, ask:

- Who made this?
- When?
- Why?
- What is missing?

Separate:

- **fact** (can be checked)
- **opinion** (someone's view)

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| Maps as sources

Maps are sources too. Read title, key, scale and direction first. Ask who made the map and for what purpose.

| Evidence

Evidence is not “anything on the internet”.

Evidence is what remains after careful checking.

One source is a clue. Two or more sources that agree are stronger. Sources that disagree are interesting — they need careful thinking, not panic.

| Writing like a Year 7 geographer and historian

Use short paragraphs:

claim → evidence → explanation

Helpful words: *because*, *therefore*, *however*, *this suggests*, *one limitation is*.

| Imagine you are...

Imagine you find an old coin under a school floorboard. Your friend shouts, “Treasure from a king!” You smile and say, “Maybe. First we look carefully. Then we ask good questions. Then we investigate with experts and maps. Then we share what we can really prove.”

That is enquiry. That is how historians and geographers work.

| Summary · Skills Toolkit

<!-- box:key-fact -->

Key points

1. Enquiry has four steps: look → ask → investigate → share.
2. Sources are raw materials of History and Geography.
3. Maps are special sources with purpose and limits.
4. Evidence is what careful checking allows us to claim.
5. Write: claim → evidence → explanation.

<!-- /box:key-fact -->

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| Check your understanding · Skills Toolkit

1. List the four enquiry steps in order.
2. What is the difference between a **source** and **evidence**?
3. Name two questions you should ask about any source.
4. Why is a tourist advert weaker than a recent atlas map for borders?
5. Harder: Write one sharp enquiry question about your local area that a map could help answer.

Two doors into the book (photographs)

| Photo A · Part 1 doorway



Maya and Lin at Machu Picchu with a compass

Maya and **Lin** stand on stone terraces at **Machu Picchu** in the Andes. They hold a compass and look to the horizon.

This photo points toward **Part 1**: ancient civilisations and landscapes — starting with the mountain world of the **Inca**.

| Photo B · Part 2 doorways



Sofia and Leo at Guimarães Castle

Sofia and **Leo** explore the walls of **Guimarães Castle** in **Portugal** — a medieval place of power and story.

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| What you will study (course map)

| Part 1 · Ancient and Pre-Columbian Civilisations and Landscapes

Chapter 1 · The Inca Empire – Empire in the Andes

- 1.1 Geography and Environment of the Andes
- 1.2 Timeline, Origins and Expansion
- 1.3 Society, Government and the Sapa Inca
- 1.4 Technology, Construction and the Mita System
- 1.5 Cuzco and the Spanish Conquest

Chapter 2 · Ancient China – Land of Invention

- 2.1 Geography and the Great Rivers
- 2.2 Timeline and Main Dynasties
- 2.3 Society, Government and Philosophy
- 2.4 Inventions, Art, the Silk Road and the Great Wall

Chapter 3 · Ancient Egypt – Gift of the Nile

- 3.1 Geography and the River Nile
- 3.2 Society, Government and Pharaohs
- 3.3 Gods, Religion and Monumental Architecture

Also in Part 1 landscapes: glaciers, rivers, Africa, Kenya (taught by school term with Geography).

| Part 2 · Europe, the UK and Portugal

Chapter 4 · Maps, the UK and Early Portugal

- 4.1 Maps Through the Ages and Key Skills
- 4.2 The European Union and the United Kingdom
- 4.3 The Foundation and Medieval History of Portugal

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| Later in the book

Review, Enquiry & Assessment

Skills and Projects

Reference Section (Glossary, Timelines, Atlas, Index)

Ready for the journey?

You now know:

- what this book is for
- how to use it
- why timelines, maps and big ideas matter
- which skills you will practise all year

Open your Thinking Journal. Write one question you hope this year will answer.

When your teacher says go, we begin **Part 1** with the mountain empire of the **Inca** — or with foundation geography and maps, following your school term order.

Welcome to *Exploring Our World – History & Geography*.

End of Introduction · Continue with Chapter 1 (Geography and You) in school term order, or as your teacher directs.

CHAPTER 1

| Chapter 1: The Inca Empire – Empire in the Andes

1.1 Geography and environment of the Andes

| Learn first · full explanation

The **Andes** are the greatest mountain chain in South America. They begin in the north, in Venezuela and Colombia, and run all the way south to Argentina and Chile. They are very high and very long: some peaks rise above **6,000 metres** (almost twenty times the height of a very tall building).

About five hundred years ago, in Inca times, the empire lay mainly in the mountains of the countries we now call:

- **Peru**
- **Bolivia**
- **Ecuador**
- and parts of **Chile** and **Argentina**

Those mountains are still in the same place today. The geography has not changed.

Inside that Andean region there were three very different kinds of environment:

- **The coast** — near the Pacific Ocean. It was very dry and desert-like, with little rain.
- **The sierra (highlands)** — the middle part of the mountains, with lower valleys where people could farm and live.
- **The humid forest** — on the other side of the mountains (the east). That forest dropped toward the **Amazon**. The Amazon is the world's largest tropical rainforest. It lies mainly in Brazil, but also reaches eastern Peru and Bolivia.

CHAPTER 1

| Check your understanding · 1.1

In the highest parts of the mountains it was very cold and the air had less **oxygen** (breathing felt harder). That is why the Inca invented **terraces** — a kind of staircase made of earth and stone on the mountain slopes. On them they could grow potatoes, quinoa and other foods. They also kept animals such as **llamas** and **alpacas**. The climate had a rainy season and a dry season, so they had to organise farming very carefully so people would not go hungry.

The Andes were both a **challenge** and an **opportunity**. At high altitude the air is thin, nights freeze, and flat farmland is scarce. Yet the mountains also gave stone for building, protection from enemies, and different **climate zones stacked one above the other** — like floors in a building. The Inca did not only live *in* the Andes: they learned to live *with* the Andes, using terraces, irrigation canals and storehouses.



Photorealistic educational scene showing the Andes, altitude zones, terraces and the location of Cuzco

| Check your understanding · 1.1

1. Why were terraces necessary in the Andes?
2. How did altitude create both challenges and opportunities?
3. Name two ways the Inca adapted farming to mountain environments.

1.2 History, origins and expansion

| Learn first · full explanation

The Inca Empire was called **Tawantinsuyu**, which means “the four regions united”. It began small in the city of **Cuzco** around the thirteenth century (the 1200s).

In the fifteenth century (the 1400s), a great leader called **Pachacuti** began to conquer many peoples and lands. After him, his sons and grandsons continued the expansion. At its height the empire was enormous: it stretched from southern Colombia to mid-Chile.

The Inca did not conquer by war alone. They also made alliances, arranged marriages, and moved groups of people from one place to another. They spread the **Quechua** language and the worship of the Sun (**Inti**).

Near the end of the empire there was a war between two brothers: **Huáscar** and **Atahualpa**. That civil war left the empire weaker just when the Spanish arrived.

The speed of growth is one of the most remarkable features of Inca history. In less than a century they created the largest empire in the pre-Columbian Americas. Roads, resettlement and a common language helped hold the empire together.

CHAPTER 1

Check your understanding · 1.2



Photorealistic classroom investigation of Inca origins, expansion and a chronological timeline

Check your understanding · 1.2

1. What does Tawantinsuyu mean?
2. How did Pachacuti and later rulers expand the empire?
3. Why did the conflict between Huáscar and Atahualpa weaken the empire?

CHAPTER 1

1.3 Society, government and the Sapa Inca

Learn first · full explanation

Inca society was carefully organised and had clear classes.

At the top stood the **Sapa Inca**, the emperor. People believed he was the son of the Sun and the owner of almost everything — land, animals and people.

Below him came the nobles. Most people were peasants. Those peasants lived in groups called **ayllus** (like large extended families that worked and lived together).

The empire was divided into four great parts, called **suyus**. There were chiefs responsible for groups of 10, 100 or 1,000 families. That made it easier to control such a large territory.

Religion was very important. The Sun (**Inti**) was the main god. Former emperors were treated as sacred even after death.

Everyone had a place and a duty. This strict organisation allowed the empire to control millions of people across extremely difficult mountain terrain. Power was both **religious** and **practical**.



Photorealistic educational scene explaining Inca society, government, ayllus and the Sapa Inca

Check your understanding · 1.3

1. Who was the Sapa Inca?
2. What was an ayllu?
3. How did religious and administrative power work together?

1.4 Technology, construction and the mita system

| Learn first · full explanation

The Inca had no wheel for carts and no iron for strong tools, yet they still achieved extraordinary things. They mainly used stone, wood, bone and soft metals such as gold, silver and copper.

Buildings

Inca builders were true artists of stone. They cut huge stones (some weighing many tonnes) and fitted them together so perfectly that almost no mortar or cement was needed. The stones sat so tightly that even a sheet of paper could hardly pass between them.

That was clever because the Andes have many **earthquakes**. The walls could “dance” a little during a tremor and not fall. We can still see these buildings today:

- **Machu Picchu** — a whole city on a mountain top
- **Sacsayhuamán** — a fortress near Cuzco with giant stones
- **Ollantaytambo** — a place with terraces and temples

Roads and messengers

The Inca built a road network of more than **30,000 kilometres** (almost the distance from Lisbon to Japan!). Those roads climbed and dropped over mountains, deserts and forests.

There were:

- bridges made of thick plant-fibre ropes (some swung a lot!)
- rest stations called **tambos**, where travellers could sleep and eat
- special messengers called **chasquis**. They ran in relays, like a race baton, carrying messages, news and even fresh fish from the coast to Cuzco in only a few days.

The mita system

Mita was how the government organised everyone’s work.

CHAPTER 1

| Check your understanding · 1.4

It worked like this:

- Each family (or group of families) had to work for the state for part of the year.
- They might build roads, make terraces, farm the emperor's lands, work in mines or serve in the army.
- It was **not** the same as slavery: people returned home after their period of service.
- In return, the government provided food, clothing and protection.

The Inca also kept many **storehouses** (called **qollqas**) across the empire. They stored potatoes, maize, quinoa and dried meat. When drought or trouble hit a region, the government opened the storehouses and shared food so people would not starve.

Photorealistic educational scene showing precise Inca stonework, roads, bridges, chasquis and mita labour

| Check your understanding · 1.4

1. How did Inca stonework respond to earthquake risk?
2. What did chasquis and tambos contribute to the road system?
3. Explain how mita worked and what the state provided in return.

1.5 Cuzco and the Spanish conquest

| Learn first · full explanation

Cuzco — capital of the empire

Cuzco was the most important city in all of **Tawantinsuyu**. The Inca believed it was the “navel of the world” (the centre of everything).

From above, the city was planned to recall the shape of a **puma** (a sacred animal). In the centre stood the **Coricancha**, the great Temple of the Sun. Its walls were covered with gold plates that shone in sunlight. There were also gardens with plants and animals made of gold and silver.

Cuzco was where the Sapa Inca lived, where great ceremonies took place, and where orders went out to the whole empire.

The arrival of the Spanish (1532)

In **1532** a Spaniard named **Francisco Pizarro** arrived with about **180 soldiers**, some horses and firearms. That was a tiny number compared with the size of the Inca Empire.

At that time the empire was weakened by civil war between two brothers:

- **Huáscar** (who controlled Cuzco)
- **Atahualpa** (who controlled the north)

Pizarro used that division. He met Atahualpa at **Cajamarca**. The Spanish prepared an ambush: when Atahualpa arrived with thousands of unarmed people for a meeting, the Spanish attacked by surprise. Within hours they captured the emperor.

Atahualpa tried to save his life with a huge ransom: a room filled with gold and two rooms filled with silver. The Inca gathered an impressive amount of precious metal. Even so, the Spanish killed Atahualpa in **1533**.

CHAPTER 1

Check your understanding · 1.5

Afterwards the Spanish entered Cuzco and took the capital. Many peoples who disliked Inca rule chose to help the Spanish. Diseases brought from Europe (especially **smallpox**) also killed thousands, because indigenous people had no immunity to them.

The Inca still fought for years (especially under **Manco Inca** and later in the region of **Vilcabamba**), but in **1572** the last emperor, **Túpac Amaru I**, was captured and executed. That ended independent Inca imperial rule. Andean peoples did **not** simply vanish.

Photorealistic evidence activity connecting Cuzco, civil war, disease, alliances and Spanish conquest

Check your understanding · 1.5

1. Why was Cuzco important?
2. How did Pizarro capture Atahualpa with a small force?
3. Identify three different factors that helped the Spanish conquest.

Chapter review

1. Choose the most important connection between geography and history in this chapter. Explain it using two pieces of evidence.
2. Select one image in the chapter. What does it help you understand that words alone do not?
3. Write one question you would investigate next and identify the evidence you would need.

CHAPTER 2

| Chapter 2: Ancient China – Land of Invention

2.1 Geography and the great rivers

| Learn first · full explanation

Ancient China lay in East Asia, in the same place as China today (a very large country).

China's geography is highly varied:

- In the west and north there are high mountains and deserts (such as the **Gobi Desert**).
- In the south there are warmer, more humid zones.
- In the centre and east there are large fertile plains.

The two most important rivers were:

- **Yellow River (Huang He)** — in the north. It is called “Yellow” because the water carries much yellow earth (**loess**). It was very fertile, but also dangerous: it often flooded and destroyed villages. People therefore called it “**China's Sorrow**” (and also, in another sense, a mother of Chinese civilisation because of the fertile soil).
- **Yangtze (Chang Jiang)** — in the centre/south. It is Asia's longest river. Its banks were also excellent for farming.

CHAPTER 2

Ancient China – Land of Invention

Thanks to these rivers, ancient Chinese people could grow much **rice** (in the south) and **millet** and **wheat** (in the north). Fertile land near the rivers helped China support many people and build a strong, long-lasting civilisation.

Mountains and deserts partly isolated China from the rest of the world. That helped Chinese culture develop in its own distinctive way for many centuries. This geography also supported the idea of China as the “**Middle Kingdom**” — a centre surrounded by other regions.

Photorealistic educational scene comparing the Yellow River, Yangtze, fertile plains, mountains and deserts

CHAPTER 2

| Check your understanding · 2.1

1. Why was the Yellow River both helpful and dangerous?
2. How did the Yellow River and Yangtze support different crops?
3. How did mountains and deserts influence contact with other regions?

2.2 Timeline and the main dynasties

| Learn first · full explanation

Ancient Chinese history is very long (more than 3,000 years). The Chinese organised time in **dynasties**. A dynasty was a family of emperors that ruled for many years. When one family lost power, another dynasty began.

Here are the most important early dynasties of Ancient China:

CHAPTER 2

| Check your understanding · 2.2

- **Xia dynasty** (about 2070–1600 BCE) — the first, though historians still debate whether it fully existed.
- **Shang dynasty** (about 1600–1046 BCE) — already used writing and bronze. They made oracles with animal bones.
- **Zhou dynasty** (1046–256 BCE) — the longest. Great philosophers such as **Confucius** and **Laozi** lived in this era. At the end there was much war (the Warring States period).
- **Qin dynasty** (221–206 BCE) — short but crucial. The first emperor, **Qin Shi Huang**, unified China for the first time. He began linking the **Great Wall** and made everyone use the same writing and measures.
- **Han dynasty** (206 BCE – 220 CE) — one of the most important and longest. China became rich and powerful. The **Silk Road** developed strongly. Many major inventions appeared or improved.

After the Han, China went through periods of division and new dynasties, but these five are the ones most studied for Ancient China.

Photorealistic classroom timeline and dynasty-cycle activity for Xia, Shang, Zhou, Qin and Han

| Check your understanding · 2.2

1. What is a dynasty?
2. Which dynasty first unified China, and what did it standardise?
3. Why is the Han dynasty important to the Silk Road story?

CHAPTER 2

2.3 Society, government and philosophy

| Learn first · full explanation

How was society organised?

Chinese society was hierarchical (it had classes):

1. The **emperor** — at the top. He was called the “**Son of Heaven**”. People believed Heaven gave him the right to rule (**Mandate of Heaven**). If the emperor was bad or if natural disasters struck, people might think he had lost that right.
2. **Officials and nobles** — helped the emperor govern.
3. **Peasants** — most of the population. They farmed the land and paid taxes.
4. **Craftspeople and merchants** — made objects and sold goods (merchants were not always highly respected).

Government

The emperor held great power. To control such a large country he used many public officials. In the **Han dynasty**, examinations began to select the best officials (instead of choosing only by family). That was a very advanced idea.

Philosophy (ideas about how to live)

Ancient Chinese thinkers thought carefully about the best way to live in society. The three most important ideas were:

CHAPTER 2

| Check your understanding · 2.3

- **Confucianism** (linked to **Confucius**) — people should respect elders, be honest and educated, and do their duty. Family and order were very important.
- **Daoism** (or Taoism, linked to **Laozi**) — live in harmony with nature and the “Dao” (the natural way of things). It preferred simplicity and calm.
- **Legalism** — believed people needed very strict laws and hard punishments to behave well. It was used strongly in the Qin dynasty.

These philosophies influenced China for thousands of years. Ideas about how people should live were just as important as armies and walls. Study beliefs with respect: describing a tradition is not the same as practising it.

Photorealistic educational scene explaining Chinese social hierarchy, government and philosophies

| Check your understanding · 2.3

1. What did the Mandate of Heaven mean?
2. Compare one central idea of Confucianism with one central idea of Daoism.
3. Why did rulers need officials to govern such a large territory?

2.4 Inventions, art, the Silk Road and the Great Wall

| Learn first · full explanation

Ancient China is famous for inventing many important things long before Europe.

Great Chinese inventions

- **Paper** (around the 2nd century CE) — before that people wrote on bamboo, wood or silk.
- The **compass** — helped people navigate and not get lost.
- **Gunpowder** — first used in fireworks, later in weapons.
- **Printing** (movable type ideas) — allowed books to be printed more quickly.
- Silk, porcelain, paper money, the seismoscope (to detect earthquakes) and many more.

Art

The Chinese made beautiful bronze pieces, embroidered silk, delicate porcelain and ink paintings. They also wrote poetry and practised **calligraphy** (artistic writing was seen as a great art).

The Silk Road

It was not one single road. It was a **network** of trade routes linking China to Central Asia, India, Persia and even Europe. “Silk Road” is a modern label; traders used many routes and markets. These routes were used for more than **1,500 years** (roughly from the 2nd century BCE to the 15th century CE).

Chinese traders mainly sold **silk** (a luxury cloth that only they knew how to make at first). In return they received gold, silver, horses, spices and other goods. The Silk Road also spread ideas, religions and inventions — not only products.

There were land routes (using camels across deserts and mountains) and later sea routes. Journeys were dangerous, so merchants rarely travelled the whole way; goods passed from trader to trader like a relay.

Important cities grew rich: **Chang’an (Xi’an)**, **Samarkand**, **Baghdad**, **Constantinople** and others.

CHAPTER 2

| Check your understanding · 2.4

From the 15th century the land Silk Road lost importance as Ottoman taxes rose and Europeans found a sea route to India (**Vasco da Gama**, 1498). Even so, the idea of Silk Road links never fully disappeared (today people even speak of a “New Silk Road”).

The Great Wall of China

Building began in the Qin dynasty and was extended over many centuries. The main aim was to protect China from nomadic peoples of the north (such as the Xiongnu). It was not one continuous wall from the start: several walls were linked over time. Today it is one of the world’s most famous monuments.

Photorealistic educational scene linking inventions, art, Silk Road routes and Great Wall frontier systems

| Check your understanding · 2.4

1. Name three influential Chinese inventions and explain one impact.
2. Why is the Silk Road better described as a network?
3. What was the main purpose of early Great Wall systems?

Chapter review

1. Choose the most important connection between geography and history in this chapter. Explain it using two pieces of evidence.
2. Select one image in the chapter. What does it help you understand that words alone do not?
3. Write one question you would investigate next and identify the evidence you would need.

CHAPTER 3

| Chapter 3: Ancient Egypt – Gift of the Nile

3.1 Geography and the River Nile

| Learn first · full explanation

Ancient Egypt lay in north-east Africa, in the same place as Egypt today. Most of the country is desert (the Sahara) — hot, dry and with almost no rain.

But one thing made life possible: the **River Nile**.

The Nile is the world's longest river. It rises in central Africa and flows **north** into the Mediterranean Sea. Every year, roughly between July and October, the river flooded its banks. When the water fell, it left a layer of black, very fertile earth (**silt**).

That is why ancient Egyptians said Egypt was the “**gift of the Nile**” (a present from the river). Without the Nile, almost nobody could have lived there.

They divided the country into two parts:

- **Upper Egypt** — the southern part, where the river is narrower
- **Lower Egypt** — the northern part, near the sea, where the river spreads into several arms (the **delta**)

CHAPTER 3

Check your understanding · 3.1

Egyptians built canals to take Nile water to the fields so they could grow wheat, barley, flax and vegetables. They also fished and kept animals. The river was the main highway: almost all travel and transport of goods used boats.

The yearly cycle was: **flood** → **planting** → **growing** → **harvest** → **waiting for the next flood**. This cycle shaped the rhythm of Egyptian life. Remember: the Nile flows north, so Upper Egypt is south. The green strip of life was the **Black Land**; the desert was the **Red Land**.

Photorealistic educational scene explaining the Nile flood cycle, Black Land, Red Land and the delta

Check your understanding · 3.1

1. Why was Egypt called the gift of the Nile?
2. Why is Upper Egypt south of Lower Egypt?
3. Explain the annual flood-to-harvest cycle.

3.2 Society, government and the pharaohs

| Learn first · full explanation

Egyptian society was organised like a **pyramid**:

1. **At the top stood the pharaoh**

The pharaoh was king and supreme leader. People believed he was a living god on Earth (son of Ra or of Horus). He held absolute power over government, army and religion. When he died he was buried with many treasures for the afterlife.

1. **Below the pharaoh** came nobles, priests and **scribes**.

Scribes were very important because they could read and write (**hieroglyphs**). Almost nobody else could write.

1. **In the middle** were craftspeople, soldiers and merchants.

1. **At the base** were peasants (most of the population). They worked the fields and paid taxes in food. When the Nile was not flooding, many were called to help build temples and pyramids.

1. **At the lowest level** were slaves (many were prisoners of war).

CHAPTER 3

Check your understanding · 3.2

Government was highly centralised. The pharaoh controlled almost everything through officials. Egypt was one of the first countries with a well-organised state: laws, taxes and a permanent army. Political power and religious power were completely joined. The pharaoh's duties included maintaining order (**ma'at**), protecting the country and serving the gods.

Famous pharaohs include, for example:

- **Narmer** (or Menes) — who unified Upper and Lower Egypt
- **Khufu** (Cheops) — who built the Great Pyramid of Giza
- **Tutankhamun** — the boy pharaoh whose almost intact tomb was found
- **Ramesses II** — one of the longest-reigning pharaohs, with many building projects

Photorealistic classroom activity explaining Egyptian social hierarchy, scribes, farming and pharaohs

Check your understanding · 3.2

1. What responsibilities did the pharaoh hold?
2. Why were scribes important?
3. How were farming, taxation and building projects connected?

3.3 Gods, religion and monumental architecture

| Learn first · full explanation

Religion was one of the most important things in Egyptian life. Egyptians believed in many gods (**polytheism**). Each god had a role:

- **Ra** — the sun god (the most important)
- **Osiris** — god of the dead and of life after death
- **Isis** — wife of Osiris, goddess of magic and protection
- **Horus** — falcon-headed god, protector of pharaohs
- **Anubis** — jackal-headed god who helped with funerals
- **Thoth** — god of writing and wisdom

Egyptians believed strongly in life after death. That is why they prepared the dead carefully:

- They performed **mummification** (removed organs, dried the body with a special salt called natron, and wrapped it in bandages)
- They placed food, clothes, jewellery and objects in the tomb for use in the afterlife
- They built secure tombs to protect the body

Monumental architecture

Egyptians were excellent builders. Their most famous works include:

CHAPTER 3

Ancient Egypt – Gift of the Nile

- **Pyramids** — huge tombs for pharaohs. The best known is the Great Pyramid of Giza (for Pharaoh **Khufu**). It is about 140 metres high and was built with millions of stone blocks. For thousands of years it was the tallest building in the world.
- **Temples** — places to worship the gods, with huge columns, giant statues and walls covered in hieroglyphs and paintings. Famous examples: Karnak and Abu Simbel.
- **Sphinxes** — statues with a lion's body and a human head (the most famous is the Great Sphinx of Giza, beside the pyramids).

These buildings showed the pharaoh's power and the importance of religion. They were built by thousands of workers (many peasants) in months when there was little farm work. Human skill and organisation built them — myths about “alien builders” fail basic historical tests.

Photorealistic educational scene connecting Egyptian gods, afterlife beliefs, pyramids, temples and the Sphinx

CHAPTER 3

Check your understanding · 3.3

1. How did belief in the afterlife affect burial practices?
2. What were pyramids and temples designed to communicate?
3. What evidence shows that organised human labour built Egyptian monuments?

Chapter review

1. Choose the most important connection between geography and history in this chapter. Explain it using two pieces of evidence.
2. Select one image in the chapter. What does it help you understand that words alone do not?
3. Write one question you would investigate next and identify the evidence you would need.

CHAPTER 4

| Part 2: Europe, the UK and Portugal

Chapter 4: Maps, the UK and Early Portugal

4.1 Maps through the ages and key skills

| Learn first · full explanation

Maps are drawings that represent the Earth or part of it. They help us know where places are, how far they are, and how to get somewhere.

How maps changed through time

- **In antiquity** — Early maps were very simple. The Babylonians (more than 2,500 years ago) made maps on clay tablets. Greeks such as Ptolemy already tried to draw the known world more carefully.
- **In the Middle Ages** — Many maps were religious. They often put Jerusalem at the centre of the world and were not very accurate.
- **In the Age of Discoveries (15th and 16th centuries)** — The Portuguese and Spanish made much better maps because they explored new continents. Maps began to show Africa, Asia and the Americas in more detail.
- **Today** — We have very accurate maps thanks to satellites and GPS. We can see the world on a phone in seconds.

Key skills for reading a map

CHAPTER 4

Check your understanding · 4.1

1. **Title** — says what the map shows.
2. **Compass rose** — shows the cardinal points (North, South, East, West).
3. **Scale** — shows the relationship between distance on the map and real distance (for example 1 cm = 100 km).
4. **Key / legend** — explains the meaning of symbols and colours (for example blue = water, green = forest).
5. **Coordinates** — latitude and longitude help locate a place exactly.
6. **Grid references** — help pinpoint a place on a map sheet.

Every map is made for a **purpose** and therefore shows some things and hides others. A tourist map is not the same tool as an official atlas page. Reading maps is a very useful skill in Geography and in everyday life.

Photorealistic educational scene comparing maps through the ages, scale, symbols, grid references and modern mapping

Check your understanding · 4.1

1. How did maps change from early symbolic representations to measured modern maps?
2. What do scale, keys and grid references allow a map user to do?
3. Why must we ask who made a map and for what purpose?

4.2 The European Union and the United Kingdom

| Learn first · full explanation

The European Union (EU)

The European Union is an organisation of European countries that have joined together to cooperate. It is **not** one single country.

Main aims:

- keep peace in Europe
- make trade between countries easier
- allow people to travel and work more freely
- protect the environment and citizens' rights

The EU has **27** member countries (as of 2026). Examples: Portugal, Spain, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Ireland...

Important EU symbols:

- the blue flag with 12 gold stars
- the anthem (based on Beethoven's "Ode to Joy")
- the shared currency: the **euro** (used by many countries, including Portugal)

The United Kingdom (UK)

The United Kingdom is formed of four nations:

- England
- Scotland
- Wales
- Northern Ireland

The capital is **London**. The main language is English.

Great Britain is the large island of England, Scotland and Wales. Northern Ireland is part of the UK but sits on the island of Ireland.

CHAPTER 4

| Check your understanding · 4.2

The UK was part of the European Union for many years, but in **2020** it left officially. That process was called **Brexit** (from “British exit”).

Today the UK is independent of the EU, but it still has trade and political links with European countries.

Photorealistic educational scene showing the four nations of the United Kingdom and its relationship with Europe

| Check your understanding · 4.2

1. Name the four nations and capitals of the United Kingdom.
2. What is the difference between Europe, the European Union and the United Kingdom?
3. How have seas connected as well as separated the UK from neighbouring places?

4.3 Foundation and medieval history of Portugal

| Learn first · full explanation

Portugal is one of Europe's oldest countries. Its medieval history is very interesting.

How Portugal was born

In the 12th century the Iberian Peninsula was divided between Christian kingdoms (in the north) and Muslim territories (in the south).

The County of Portucale (a region in the north) belonged to the kingdom of León. Count **Henry of Burgundy** and his wife **Teresa** ruled this land. Their son **Afonso Henriques** wanted independence. After several struggles (including the famous Battle of Ourique in 1139), Afonso Henriques proclaimed himself king.

In **1143**, by the **Treaty of Zamora**, the king of León recognised Afonso Henriques as king of Portugal.

Later, in **1179**, the Pope officially recognised the Kingdom of Portugal.

The Middle Ages in Portugal (12th to 15th centuries)

- **The Reconquista** — Portuguese kings conquered land from Muslim rulers, advancing south. In 1249, with the conquest of the Algarve by **Afonso III**, Portugal's borders became almost like today's.
- **Important kings:**
 - **Afonso Henriques** — the first king (founder of Portugal)
 - **Dinis** — the “Farmer King”. He planted forests, created Portugal's first university (in Lisbon, later Coimbra) and strengthened borders.
 - **John I** — won the Battle of Aljubarrota (1385) against Castile and secured independence. It began the Avis dynasty.
- **Medieval society** — there was the king, the nobles, the clergy (priests and nuns), the burghers (merchants) and the peasants. Many peasants lived on lords' land and worked in return for protection.

CHAPTER 4

Check your understanding · 4.3

At the end of the Middle Ages, Portugal was ready for the great adventure of the Discoveries, which begins in the 15th century. Study Christian–Muslim history carefully and respectfully: explain causes and consequences; do not insult any faith or celebrate violence.

Photorealistic educational scene connecting Iberian geography, castles, Afonso Henriques and medieval Portugal

Check your understanding · 4.3

1. How did Iberian geography influence the emergence of Portugal?
2. Why is Afonso Henriques important in the foundation story?
3. What roles did castles, towns, farming and religion play in medieval Portugal?

Chapter review

1. Explain one connection between maps, political geography and historical change.
2. Select one image and explain the evidence it communicates.
3. Write an enquiry question and identify two sources needed to investigate it.

CONCLUSION

| Review, Enquiry & Assessment

Review

| Part 1 · Ancient and Pre-Columbian civilisations

- **Inca:** empire in the Andes mountains (Peru, Bolivia, Ecuador...). Capital Cuzco. Sapa Inca, mita, terraces, roads and stone buildings. Conquered by the Spanish from 1532.
- **Ancient China:** great rivers (Yellow and Yangtze). Dynasties (Qin and Han important). Confucianism, Daoism and Legalism. Inventions: paper, compass, gunpowder, silk. Silk Road and Great Wall.
- **Ancient Egypt:** “gift of the Nile”. Pharaohs, hieroglyphs, mummification, pyramids and temples. Gods such as Ra, Osiris and Isis. Rosetta Stone allowed deciphering of hieroglyphs (Champollion, 1822).

| Part 2 · Europe, the United Kingdom and Portugal

- **Maps:** evolution from antiquity to GPS. Essential elements: title, compass rose, scale, key.
- **European Union and United Kingdom:** EU with 27 countries. UK left in 2020 (Brexit).
- **Medieval Portugal:** foundation with Afonso Henriques (1143). Reconquista to the Algarve (1249). Kings such as Dinis and John I.

| Extra themes explored

- **Portuguese Discoveries:** Prince Henry the Navigator, Bartolomeu Dias, Vasco da Gama (1497–1499), Pedro Álvares Cabral (Brazil, 1500).
- **Silk Road:** trade network between China and Europe. Carried silk, spices, ideas and religions.
- **Plague of Justinian** (541 CE) and **Black Death** (1347–1351): both caused by the same bacterium. Killed tens of millions and changed society.
- **Vasco da Gama:** opened the sea route to India. Economic consequences: Portugal grew rich from spices, Lisbon became a great port, Venice lost power.

CONCLUSION**Enquiry**

Choose **two** of the following questions and investigate in more detail (use what you learned + simple research):

1. Why did great ancient civilisations (Inca, China, Egypt) develop near mountains or great rivers?
2. Compare Inca government with Ancient Egyptian government. What similarities and differences do you find?
3. How did the Silk Road and, later, Vasco da Gama's sea route change world trade?
4. How did the great plagues (Justinian and Black Death) change ordinary people's lives?
5. Why was Portugal able to pioneer the Discoveries, and what difficulties did it face?

Assessment

Section A — Short answers (6 marks)

1. Name the two great rivers of Ancient China.
2. Who was the first king of Portugal?
3. In what year did Vasco da Gama reach India?
4. What did mita mean in the Inca Empire?
5. What object made it possible to decipher hieroglyphs?
6. Which European country left the European Union in 2020?

Section B — Developed answers (8 marks)

1. Explain why the River Nile was so important for Ancient Egypt.
2. Give two economic consequences of Vasco da Gama's voyage.
3. Compare the Plague of Justinian with the Black Death (one similarity and one difference).
4. Why were maps essential for the Portuguese Discoveries?

Section C — Critical thinking (6 marks)

1. "Chinese inventions changed the world." Do you agree? Justify with two examples.
2. Do you think the Discoveries brought more benefits or more problems? Explain your opinion with arguments.

Total: 20 marks

CONCLUSION

Skills and Projects

Project 1 — Historical map

Draw a map showing: the Inca Empire; Ancient China; Ancient Egypt; the Silk Road; Vasco da Gama’s voyage. Use different colours and a clear key.

Project 2 — Timeline

Build a timeline of the most important events from Ancient Egypt to the Portuguese Discoveries (at least 10 dates).

Project 3 — Historical newspaper

Write a front-page news story as if you were a journalist of the time on one of these topics: Vasco da Gama’s arrival in India; the Black Death in a European city; the building of a pyramid.

Map skill

On a blank world outline map, locate and label: Andes; River Nile; Yellow River; Cape of Good Hope; Calicut; Lisbon.

Reference Section

Glossary

Word	Simple meaning
Sapa Inca	Emperor of the Inca
Mita	Rotating compulsory labour in the Inca Empire
Hieroglyphs	Sacred writing of Ancient Egypt
Pharaoh	King of Ancient Egypt
Dynasty	Family of rulers who succeed one another in power
Silk Road	Trade routes between China and Europe
Caravel	Portuguese ship used in the Discoveries
Brexit	The United Kingdom’s exit from the European Union
Reconquista	Process of taking Iberian lands from Muslim rule (study carefully)
Bubo	Swelling caused by plague

CONCLUSION**| Timelines (summary)**

- **c. 3100 BCE** — Start of unified Ancient Egypt
- **c. 1600–1046 BCE** — Shang dynasty (China)
- **221–206 BCE** — Qin dynasty (unification of China)
- **541–549 CE** — Plague of Justinian
- **1139–1143** — Foundation of Portugal (Afonso Henriques)
- **1347–1351** — Black Death in Europe
- **1415** — Conquest of Ceuta (start of Portuguese expansion)
- **1498** — Vasco da Gama reaches India
- **1500** — Pedro Álvares Cabral reaches Brazil
- **1532** — Start of Spanish conquest of the Inca Empire
- **1822** — Champollion reads hieroglyphs
- **2020** — Brexit (UK leaves the EU)

| Atlas (maps to consult)

- Map of the Inca Empire
- Map of Ancient China with the Yellow River and Yangtze
- Map of Ancient Egypt (Upper and Lower Egypt)
- Map of the Silk Road
- Map of Vasco da Gama's voyage
- Map of Europe with European Union countries
- Map of medieval Portugal (Reconquista)

CONCLUSION**| Index of main topics (teaching order in this book)**

- Andes / Inca → Chapters 4–6 (and this full unit Chapter 1 block)
 - Ancient China → Chapters 7, 10, 11 (and this full unit Chapter 2 block)
 - Ancient Egypt → Chapters 12, 15 (and this full unit Chapter 3 block)
 - Hieroglyphs and Rosetta Stone → Chapter 15 (and this full unit)
 - Maps and skills → Chapter 2
 - European Union and United Kingdom → Chapter 3
 - Medieval Portugal / Discoveries / Vasco da Gama / plagues → Chapter 16 (and this full unit)
 - Silk Road → Chapter 11 (and this full unit)
-

End of full explanations and questions unit · Year 7 Humanities · Exploring Our World – History & Geography · Prime School